

The Ideology of Standard English and Cultural Alienation in Pakistan: A Content Analysis of English Textbooks in Non-Elite Private Primary Schools in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa

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Abstract

This study investigates the presence and propagation of standard language ideology and cultural alienation in the English textbook used in primary schools across Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, Pakistan. While English is positioned as a global language of power and opportunity, this research highlights how it simultaneously reinforces cultural and linguistic hierarchies through educational content. This study analyzed a grade 3 English textbook from a non-elite private school using qualitative content analysis. The study employs the theoretical frameworks of linguistic neo-imperialism and standard language ideology to examine how the textbook depicts Western culture, language, and values, often normalizing them as superior or universal. The findings reveal a strong emphasis on Western literary content, visual representation, and cultural practices, while local cultural identities and literature are underrepresented or distorted. The research also uncovers hidden ideological patterns in curriculum design, reflecting how educational policy decisions privilege Western

norms over local realities: such content fosters identity dislocation, cultural hybridity, and alienation among students.

Additionally, the selection of textbooks suggests a lack of accountability in aligning curricular content with Pakistan's cultural, religious, and linguistic context. This study argues that the uncritical adoption of such content perpetuates linguistic and cultural hegemony. It calls for a reassessment of language policy and textbook development practices to ensure educational materials foster inclusive, locally grounded identities. The research contributes to ongoing debates on post-colonial language planning, identity formation, and ideological control in multilingual education systems.

Keywords: linguistic neo-imperialism, standard language ideology, English textbooks, cultural imperialism, identity, qualitative content analysis.

1.Introduction

Neo-linguistic imperialism is a contemporary extension of Phillipson's concept of linguistic imperialism. Scholars argue that it represents a new phase of imperialism in which dominance is no longer maintained through territorial occupation but through global systems of power, knowledge, and capital (Yu, 2020). Unlike colonial-era language imposition, external forces no longer directly enforce English in postcolonial societies; rather, local institutions actively sustain its dominance. English has become deeply embedded in education, economy, politics, and social structures, enabling linguistic hegemony to continue through internal practices. Phillipson (2016) argues that linguistic imperialism remains a powerful and evolving phenomenon that adapts to new social and technological contexts.

In contemporary globalization, English neo-imperialism operates through subtler mechanisms, particularly in education, media, and international mobility (Zeng, 2023). English has acquired hegemonic status as a global language, reinforced by educational institutions in postcolonial societies, where it is often associated with intelligence, progress, and social advancement (Lucas, 2021; Bacon, 2018). Schools play a central role in producing and maintaining linguistic hierarchies by privileging certain languages, cultures, and communities (Apple, 1982). Through English education, linguistic and cultural inequalities are reproduced, reinforcing dominant discourses and socioeconomic power relations (Pennycook, 1995).

Language ideology explains how individuals perceive and evaluate languages and their uses. Silverstein (1979) defines linguistic ideology as a set of beliefs through which speakers justify and rationalize language practices. In this context, the global spread of English strengthens the dominance of powerful linguistic groups and maintains the relationship between the center and the periphery (Phillipson, 1992).

English textbooks are an important mechanism for transmitting linguistic and cultural ideologies. By privileging particular linguistic norms and cultural traditions, textbooks can normalize dominant perspectives and encourage learners to accept them as universal (Williams, 1989). Standard language ideology promotes an idealized and homogeneous form of language, often imposed as the most legitimate variety (Lippi-Green, 2012). The preference for British and

American English in English language textbooks reflects this ideology and reinforces Standard English norms (Gray, 2002).

In the Pakistani context, textbooks provide an important lens through which students construct their understanding of language, identity, and the world. The representation of language and culture in these materials can either support or marginalize students' linguistic and cultural identities. Standard language ideology often suppresses alternative varieties by reducing their prestige and legitimacy (Lippi-Green, 2012). Therefore, examining English textbooks is essential for understanding how language discourses establish and maintain the dominance of particular languages, cultures, and social groups.

McKay (2002) emphasizes that English as an international language should enable learners to express their own identities and perspectives rather than imitate native-speaker norms. However, in Pakistan, Standard English remains closely associated with economic opportunities, social status, and academic success. Consequently, English functions not only as a means of communication but also as a form of social inclusion and exclusion. Textbooks that prioritize Standard English norms may unintentionally reinforce the belief that limited English proficiency restricts access to global opportunities and social mobility.

The study attempts to answer the following research questions:

- What dynamics of standard language ideology exist, and how are they constructed and operationalized in textbooks from Pakistani non-elite private primary English schools?
- How do hidden ideological patterns in textbook design contribute to cultural alienation and identity dislocation among young learners in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa?

2. Literature Review

2.1 Main Features or Driving Forces of Linguistic Neo-Imperialism

In the era of globalization, the imperial influence of English is no longer limited to former colonial powers; instead, it operates through its status as a dominant global language. Unlike traditional colonialism, which relied on territorial occupation and direct cultural control, linguistic neo-imperialism functions through the institutionalization of English in postcolonial societies. English has become deeply embedded in education, economy, politics, and social structures, making these societies dependent on the language. As a result, linguistic dominance is maintained not through external force but through internal systems that continue to privilege English and shape linguistic practices.

1. Global Education and Academia in the Lap of Linguistic Neo-Imperialism

Across most research produced worldwide, English has emerged as the principal medium of publication and dissemination in education. Beyond linguistic neo-imperialism, several factors have contributed to English's popularity as the global instructional language of choice, including its complex historical development, superior academic resources, and the creation of international research databases and citation indexes (Zeng et al., 2023). Major academic publishers require

research paper titles and abstracts to be written in English, reinforcing its status as the dominant language of global academia. English carries the power of acceptance and success in the competitive world of scholarly publishing. Hagve (2020) reports that major publishers control over 50% of the academic publishing market, with Elsevier alone accounting for more than 16%. The academic publishing industry generates revenues exceeding \$19 billion, placing it alongside the music and entertainment industries. Through English-language publications, these companies generate substantial and continuous profits, strengthening English's linguistic hegemony and fostering linguistic neo-imperialism in higher education (Zeng et al., 2023).

Researchers and educators increasingly publish in English-language international journals because higher education institutions compete for global recognition and rankings, while leading publishers primarily accept English-language articles. The dominance of English in academic publishing has further consolidated its hegemony. Investigating why researchers publish in English rather than their native languages, Stockemer and Wigginton (2019), in their survey of more than 800 authors publishing with Springer Nature, found that non-native English-speaking scholars wrote approximately 60% of their research articles in English. Rather than institutional pressure alone, researchers believed that publishing in English enhanced the international visibility and prestige of their scholarship. Likewise, Hamel (2007, p. 54) argues that indigenous languages "rarely appear in the debates about languages in science," as they are often considered incapable of expressing scientific thought and research findings. Such perceptions deliberately position indigenous languages as inferior within academic and scientific discourse.

Following colonialism, English came to be viewed in many post-colonial societies as both a barrier to higher education and social prestige and a pathway to academic and professional success (Sibayan & Gonzalez, 1996; Lai, 2019). Rather than strengthening local and national languages as media of education and development, many post-colonial nations kept English at the center of their educational systems. Consequently, English assumed a dominant role in educational policies and practices. English proficiency became a prerequisite for selecting talented individuals and a key criterion for educational and professional advancement. Competence in English is frequently regarded as a marker of intelligence and ability, while those lacking English proficiency are often perceived as less capable (Zeng, 2023).

Most universities using English as the medium of instruction require standardized proficiency tests such as TOEFL or IELTS. Even students pursuing doctoral studies in English linguistics or literature often need these certifications when seeking international opportunities. Beyond assessing language ability, these examinations generate billions of dollars annually and contribute significantly to the economies that administer them. Furthermore, regardless of subject matter, many countries promote English-medium education from primary school to higher education. In Southeast Asian countries such as Malaysia, Singapore, and the Philippines, English functions not only as a subject but also as the medium of instruction across educational levels. This expansion often overlooks multilingual populations and local language ecologies. Educational policies and textbooks increasingly portray English as a linguistic bridge and gateway to the global community (Duan, 2019).

Although British and American colonial power has declined, higher education systems influenced by these traditions continue to dominate many post-colonial countries, preserving English as the principal language of education. Even non-English-speaking nations increasingly establish English-medium universities and programs, receiving considerable support from policymakers and

educational stakeholders (Mahboob & Cruz, 2013). As a result, English continues to function not only as the primary language of instruction but also as a symbol of intellectual competence and international communication (Ponce & Lucas, 2021).

English language education is widely regarded as essential for individual advancement, economic development, and national prosperity. Language learning, particularly English, is viewed as an investment in human capital that enhances knowledge, productivity, and economic opportunities. However, in the neo-colonial era, English language education has also replaced earlier forms of colonial exploitation by reinforcing linguistic hierarchies and advancing the interests of core English-speaking nations. Therefore, while promoting English language education in peripheral countries, educators should remain vigilant against the perpetuation of linguistic neo-imperialism.

3 Research Methodology

3.1 Research Design

The exploratory research design chosen for this study is supported by the social constructivist epistemological paradigm (Walliman, 2011), which regards reality as multifaceted, fluid, and context-dependent. The exploratory research approach is suitable because it investigates the patterns of linguistic Neo-imperialism and Standard language ideology at the micro level. Since the study aims to identify the dominant linguistic, ideological, cultural, hegemonic, and identity themes in the English textbook, a qualitative methodology was adopted. Content analysis was used for data analysis, while Linguistic neo-imperialism and Standard language ideology served as the theoretical framework.

3.2 Theoretical Framework

This research was supported by a theoretical framework centered on Standard language ideology as part of linguistic neo-imperialism, as presented by Rosina Lippi-Green and Jie Zeng (2012, 2023). Standard language ideology is viewed as a way of perpetuating linguistic neo-imperialism. A framework combining the concepts of Standard language ideology and Linguistic Neo-Imperialism was applied to the primary English textbook, Level 3, of Pakistan's non-elite private schools. According to Silverstein (1979), language ideology is a system of views concerning language that users articulate as a rationalization or explanation for how they perceive its structure and utilization.

Linguistic neo-imperialism refers to the dominance of a language driven by internal dynamics and characterized by hegemonic power. Lippi-Green (2012) argues that the idea of the standard language is carefully cultivated and spread with enormous success, allowing it to endure. The following characteristics of Standard language ideology and English linguistic neo-imperialism were identified:

- **Locally driven:** The population promotes and preserves English because of its economic advantages.
- **Structurally motivated:** Social institutions prescribe English for inclusivity and conformity.
- **Colonial/Imperial attitude:** Indigenous languages are viewed as inferior, while dominant languages are regarded as international and standard.

- **Normalized actualization:** The colonial language remains deeply ingrained and is presented as the status quo.
- **Standard language ideology:** A predisposition favoring a written language portrayed as idealized, homogeneous, and abstracted.
- **Suppression of variation:** Standard English ideology undermines other English dialects and places them in a subordinate position.

These aspects demonstrate how economic motivations, structural influence, colonial attitudes, and normalization contribute to the continued dominance of English.

3.3 Data Collection

Data on non-elite private primary schools were collected from Peshawar, the capital of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa. Peshawar was selected because it is an old commercial city and represents the province's population. The researcher analyzed the Grade 3 English textbook of non-elite private primary schools in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa to identify the elements of linguistic neo-imperialism and Standard language ideology. The data were collected from the textbook's reading passages, dialogues, images, exercises, cultural notes, and case studies.

3.4 Sample Selection and Rationale

This study adopts a purposeful focal-case sampling strategy by analyzing the Grade 3 textbook of the *Cambridge Global English* series (adapted for local private networks). While the empirical data for this paper are drawn specifically from the Grade 3 text, this selection serves as a representative proxy for the broader primary curriculum. The textbook series operates as a standardized, vertically aligned continuum from Grade 1 through Grade 7, authored by the same core editorial team and structured around identical pedagogical principles.

Preliminary scoping revealed that the ideological patterns, visual representations, and privileging of Western target cultures remain consistent across all volumes in the series. Therefore, Grade 3 was selected as a focal case to avoid structural redundancy while capturing a critical developmental transition point where young learners move from basic literacy to conceptual, content-based reading. Examining this specific level provides an in-depth, nuanced qualitative analysis of how standard language ideology and cultural alienation are operationalized without diluting the inquiry through repetitive cross-grade cataloging.

4. Data Analysis of Non-Elite Private Primary Schools' English Textbook

4.1 Products in Cambridge Global English APSACS, Level

Yeun's approach focuses on how language is used to assert power and dominance. It views language as a tool of colonialism and imperialism, used to control and exploit others.

On page 11 of Unit One, the textbook primarily features Western poets. It does not adequately represent Pakistani literature and cultural perspectives, creating an imbalance and marginalizing local voices. Including poems by Western poets in an English-language textbook used in Pakistan presents a complex challenge. While exposing students to diverse literary voices and global perspectives can be beneficial, the potential drawbacks cannot be ignored.

The lack of representation of Pakistani literature can reinforce the notion that Western literature is superior, marginalizing Pakistani authors and limiting students' exposure to their own cultural heritage and literary traditions. The absence of cultural context for Western poems can hinder comprehension and engagement, as students may struggle to understand the historical, social, and cultural nuances embedded within them. Furthermore, Western poems often reflect Western values and experiences. If not carefully selected and presented, they may promote Western cultural norms as universal or superior, resulting in a subtle form of cultural imperialism.

The lack of emphasis on Pakistani literature also limits students' opportunities to connect with their cultural identity and heritage. Literature plays a crucial role in shaping cultural identity; therefore, prioritizing Western literature may distance students from their literary traditions and cultural roots. A more balanced approach that prioritizes Pakistani literature, provides cultural context, and avoids cultural bias is essential for a meaningful and culturally sensitive learning experience.

To mitigate these drawbacks, the textbook should prioritize poems by Pakistani authors while maintaining a balanced inclusion of Western poets. Adequate cultural context should accompany all poems through explanatory notes and discussions. The textbook should also connect Western poems with Pakistani literature by comparing themes, styles, and values. Collaboration with Pakistani writers, educators, and cultural experts would ensure that the textbook remains culturally sensitive, relevant, and engaging for Pakistani students.

Examples:

- “*Rope Rhyme*” by Elonise Greenfield (Unit 1, p. 11)
- “*The End*” by A. A. Milne (Unit 2, p. 24)

The image on page 20, depicting a Greek wedding, reinforces the potential for Neo-English Imperialism by prioritizing a foreign cultural tradition over Pakistani ones. This lack of representation marginalizes the source culture despite Pakistan's rich diversity of wedding traditions across regions and communities. Including Pakistani weddings and highlighting their hybrid nature would have provided a more authentic representation. Exploring universal themes such as joy, celebration, family bonding, and the passage of time could have promoted cultural understanding instead of emphasizing cultural differences.

Similarly, while the textbook includes examples from international cultures such as South Korea and Hispanic traditions, it should give greater prominence to Pakistani birthday traditions. A balanced presentation would allow students to appreciate both their own cultural heritage and international cultures. By focusing on shared themes such as family togetherness and celebration while avoiding stereotypes, the textbook can provide a more inclusive and culturally sensitive learning experience.

Likewise, the analysis of the image on page 27 focuses primarily on international cultures while neglecting the Pakistani source culture. Cultural representation centers on food and traditional clothing from other cultures but overlooks Pakistani names, settings, and cultural elements. Including these aspects would provide a more balanced representation and strengthen students' connection with their own cultural identity.

The images on pages 28–29 attempt to represent cultural diversity; however, they provide limited reflection of the source culture, Pakistani society. The dominance of international representations creates a cultural imbalance and weakens students’ connection with their own context. Incorporating authentic Pakistani names, historical places, the Northern Areas, local sports such as cricket, traditional clothing, cuisine, and cultural practices would make the material more relevant and strengthen cultural identity.

The analysis of Unit 3, *Deserts* (p. 35), reveals a subtle privileging of global content over local knowledge. Although the lesson promotes international awareness, the limited inclusion of Pakistani examples risks marginalizing students’ cultural experiences. A balanced representation of both global and local perspectives would allow students to appreciate world knowledge while remaining connected to their own heritage.

The discussion of desert animals on page 37 similarly reflects this imbalance. The focus on the jerboa and fennec fox from the Sahara and Gobi deserts overlooks relevant Pakistani examples, such as species found in the Thar Desert and Balochistan. Including local wildlife, conservation efforts, and ecological connections would strengthen students’ understanding while maintaining the lesson’s global dimension.

The story on page 40 includes Muslim characters, Hassan and Ibrahim, but does not provide meaningful Pakistani cultural references. Including diverse ethnic, religious, and regional identities, along with local foods, festivals, and traditions, would create a more authentic representation of Pakistan’s cultural diversity and improve students’ engagement.

Similarly, page 42 reveals an unequal treatment of cultures. While stories from countries such as Mexico receive cultural contextualization, *Two Friends* lacks specific Pakistani cultural markers. This decontextualized portrayal reduces the visibility of Pakistani culture and limits students’ ability to relate the text to their own experiences.

Grammar lessons, including prepositions, also provide opportunities for cultural integration. Instead of relying primarily on Western settings, the textbook could use Pakistani contexts such as markets, villages, festivals, and traditional clothing. Such examples would make grammar learning more meaningful by connecting language with students’ everyday experiences.

The poem *Grayish, Greenish* by David M. Schwartz and Yael Schy further highlights the imbalance in literary representation. Although the poem itself is culturally neutral, its inclusion reflects the broader dominance of international authors while Pakistani writers and perspectives remain underrepresented. Incorporating more works by Pakistani poets and authors would promote cultural appreciation and a stronger sense of identity among learners.

The portrayal of young inventors on page 62, despite including a Muslim name such as Khadijah, lacks meaningful Pakistani representation. Similarly, pages 64–65 focus mainly on international inventors while overlooking Pakistani contributions. Including Pakistani scientists, inventors, and innovators would give students culturally relevant role models and show that creativity and innovation are not limited to Western societies.

The lesson *Carrying Things* (Unit 5), particularly the poem *The Straw – 1888*, reinforces this imbalance by focusing exclusively on Marvin Stone while excluding contributions from Muslim and Pakistani scholars. References to figures such as Jabir ibn Hayyan, Al-Jazari, and Dr. Abdus Salam would broaden students' understanding of scientific heritage and present innovation as a shared human achievement.

Unit 6, Lesson 5, *Baby Dinosaurs*, similarly overlooks Pakistan's scientific contributions. While the lesson emphasizes John Horner's discovery of dinosaur nests and eggs, it ignores significant Pakistani paleontological discoveries, including *Isisaurus colberti*, Titanosaur fossils, and *Pakisaurus balochistani*. Including local examples would demonstrate that scientific knowledge is produced globally and would increase students' sense of pride and relevance.

Unit 7, Lesson 3, *Codes and Puzzles*, uses *Prince Henry's Party* as a problem-solving context but misses an opportunity to connect the activity with students' cultural experiences. A setting based on a Mughal or Lodhi *dastarkhwan*, incorporating local names, foods, and traditions, could achieve the same learning objectives while promoting cultural familiarity.

Likewise, Unit 7, Lesson 5, *A Nasreddin Story*, offers limited cultural contextualization by vaguely attributing the story to Turkey. A stronger connection could be established through regional storytelling traditions, such as the widely known tales of Akbar and Birbal, which similarly emphasize wisdom and problem-solving. Such inclusion would validate local narratives and strengthen students' cultural connections.

Unit 9, Lesson 1, *Big and Little*, continues the pattern of Western-centered representation. The depiction of Western families, names, clothing, and technological achievements presents Western culture as the dominant norm while Pakistani lifestyles and contributions remain absent. Incorporating local families, traditions, and achievements would create a more inclusive and culturally responsive learning environment.

4.2 Perspectives in Cambridge Global English APSACS, Level 3

Through the lens of Yeun's Neo-English Imperialistic approach, this textbook page, although intended for Pakistani students in KP, embodies a form of cultural colonization. Delivered entirely in English, it positions Western language and knowledge as dominant. The focus on the Western-invented straw reinforces a narrative of Western ingenuity while erasing local contributions. The omission of Pakistani and Pashtun figures, particularly Dr. Ayub Khan Ommaya and his groundbreaking Omayyad reservoir, privileges Western achievements and renders local innovation invisible. Although the textbook claims to be "specially edited" for the region, it remains firmly rooted in a Western-centric worldview. Instead of highlighting local traditions or scientific achievements, it presents a simplified narrative that reinforces dependence on Western knowledge.

Page 68 of Unit 5, "Inventors and Inventions," exemplifies cultural imperialism by focusing solely on the Western invention of the straw while ignoring the rich history of Pakistani, Pashtun, and Muslim innovation. This selective presentation denies students access to their own heritage and perpetuates linguistic and cultural imperialism.

Although the textbook attempts to engage Pakistani students by using local names in initial exercises, it ultimately favors the Western target culture over the Pakistani source culture. The shift to the Western name "Luis" in Exercise 3, the ambiguous depiction of the child in Exercise 1, and the emphasis on English grammar through Western-oriented activities such as "climbed a mountain" and "touched an elephant" demonstrate a disconnect from students' lived realities in Peshawar. This tokenistic use of local names fails to conceal the underlying linguistic and visual imperialism, subtly reinforcing the dominance of Western culture and language while neglecting the cultural heritage of the students it is intended to serve (Linse & Schottman, 96).

4.3 Practices in Cambridge Global English APSACS, Level 3

The images are analyzed through Yeun's Neo-English Imperialistic approach, which examines how English language teaching materials perpetuate colonial power structures and represent different cultures. The analysis focuses on the representation of Pakistani culture in the English textbook used in the Army Public Schools and Colleges System, one of the elite educational networks operating across Pakistan.

The images incorporate recognizable Pakistani cultural symbols such as henna-decorated hands and a mosque, most likely the Badshahi Mosque, reflecting Islamic traditions and cultural identity. While these elements represent important aspects of Pakistani society, they reduce Pakistani culture largely to religion and tradition, overlooking the country's ethnic, linguistic, and regional diversity. Although the textbook seeks to represent local culture, its exclusive use of English and its adherence to Western educational norms continue to reinforce unequal cultural and linguistic power relations.

The title "Working Together" and the accompanying activities promote cooperation and communication, values appreciated in Pakistani society. However, the illustration limits this collaboration to Muslim children preparing a *dastarkhwan* for iftar near a mosque. A more inclusive representation involving children from different religious communities would have better reflected Pakistan's multicultural identity and strengthened the concept of working together beyond a single religious context.

On page 10 of Unit 1, the textbook emphasizes the source culture while providing limited exposure to target and international cultures. Such imbalance restricts students' intercultural understanding and may reinforce ethnocentric perspectives. A more balanced representation of local and international cultures would encourage intercultural competence and broaden students' understanding of diverse cultural values and practices.

Similarly, Unit 2, "Wedding Customs" (p. 23) reflects a significant cultural imbalance. Although henna is mentioned, it is associated with India rather than Pakistan, while greater emphasis is placed on Western, Japanese, and Hawaiian wedding traditions. Core Pakistani wedding practices, including *Nikah*, *Mehndi*, *Barat*, *Rukhsati*, *Walima*, *Attan*, *Jootha Chupai*, and other regional traditions, are absent. This selective representation privileges international customs and marginalizes Pakistani cultural heritage, reinforcing Western practices as the educational norm while limiting students' opportunities to develop cultural pride.

The same pattern continues on page 26, where the lesson on birthdays provides a detailed explanation of the Mexican piñata tradition but omits authentic Pakistani birthday celebrations commonly observed in Peshawar and other parts of the country. By prioritizing an international tradition while excluding local practices centered on family gatherings and simple celebrations, the textbook creates cultural displacement and subtly reinforces the superiority of foreign customs. This imbalance weakens students' connection to their own cultural identity and reflects Yeun's Neo-English Imperialistic perspective, in which Western or globalized cultural practices are privileged over the source culture.

4.4 Persons in Cambridge Global English APSACS, Level 3

Although the language activities follow standard teaching practices, the lesson lacks Pakistani cultural relevance. A listening task based on a Christian wedding may feel unfamiliar to predominantly Muslim students in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, while the vocabulary and craft activities remain culturally neutral. The absence of local contexts and culturally appropriate visuals reduces engagement and weakens the connection between language learning and students' lived experiences (Linse & Schottman, 2021).

The poem *The End* by A. A. Milne, accompanied by images of a fair-skinned blonde child and Western toys, reflects a Western-centric perspective. The lack of local cultural markers, familiar settings, and diverse ethnic representation limits students' identification with the material and may contribute to cultural alienation.

Despite being marketed as a localized edition, the lesson presents optical illusions and spatial concepts without any Pakistani cultural context. Its culturally neutral illustrations overlook students' local experiences, reinforce Western norms, and miss an opportunity to integrate culturally relevant English language learning.

The inclusion of Drew Lamm's *The Straw* and the exclusive focus on Western inventor Marvin Stone reinforce a Western-centered narrative of innovation. The omission of Pakistani inventors and local achievements marginalizes indigenous knowledge, reducing cultural relevance and limiting students' sense of identity and belonging.

The *Inventors and Inventions* unit illustrates neo-imperialism by privileging Western figures while excluding Pakistani personalities and cultural references. The "dream home," adapted from a Western author, marginalizes Pakistan's rich architectural heritage and presents Western creativity as the dominant model. The absence of Pakistani architects, designers, or local housing traditions creates cultural alienation and weakens students' cultural identity and intellectual empowerment.

The "Prince Henry's Party" puzzle in Unit 7 reflects a Western-centered narrative through European characters and settings while excluding culturally familiar figures such as Akbar and Birbal, as well as traditional Pakistani social practices. This omission sidelines indigenous knowledge, reinforces Western cultural dominance, and limits students' connection with their own heritage.

Although the textbook attempts to include source culture materials, these efforts remain superficial. The "Two Friends" story employs Muslim names and a desert setting but lacks attribution and cultural context, reducing it to a generic moral lesson. This weak representation marginalizes Pakistani storytelling traditions and reinforces the dominance of Western narratives.

Similarly, the "Nasreddin Story" in Unit 7 attributes the tale only to "Turkey" without acknowledging its wider cultural significance or oral tradition. The lack of contextualization and attribution reduces indigenous cultural agency, presenting inclusivity only superficially while maintaining a hierarchical knowledge framework that marginalizes local storytelling traditions (Linse & Schottman, 98–100).

5. Conclusion

In conclusion, the textbook consistently marginalizes Pakistani culture by excluding local products, persons, practices, and perspectives while privileging Western and international contexts. This imbalance weakens students' connection to their cultural identity and limits the textbook's relevance for Pakistani learners. Rather than fostering national belonging, the material promotes a Western-oriented worldview that overlooks the learners' lived experiences.

The analysis of the Grade 3 English textbook for non-elite private primary schools in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa addresses the study's research questions and yields the following findings:

1. The textbook systematically excludes Pakistani cultural elements, including local products, people, practices, and perspectives, despite being designed for Pakistani students.
2. This lack of authentic cultural representation reduces the textbook's relevance and limits students' engagement by failing to reflect their social and cultural realities.
3. The omission of local culture may contribute to feelings of alienation, weakening students' sense of cultural identity, national pride, and belonging.
4. The dominance of Western cultural narratives may encourage students to perceive foreign cultures as more valuable, diminishing appreciation for Pakistan's own cultural heritage.

6. Implications and Recommendations

1. Inappropriate Textbook Selection in Private Schools Implication: Private schools often adopt foreign or imported textbooks without critically evaluating their cultural relevance, resulting in materials that may not align with local values and contexts.

Recommendation: Education authorities should establish clear textbook selection and approval criteria and encourage the use of locally developed, culturally relevant, and curriculum-aligned materials.

2. Cultural Bias in Literary Materials Implication: Western literary texts may reflect values and experiences unfamiliar to Pakistani students, potentially reinforcing cultural dominance when presented without critical examination.

Recommendation: Teachers should adopt critical pedagogy approaches and receive training to help students analyze cultural representations and engage with diverse perspectives.

3. Misrepresentation and Erasure of Indigenous Cultures. Implication: Pakistani cultures are often underrepresented, anonymized, or altered, while Western authors and traditions receive greater visibility and recognition.

Recommendation: Policymakers should ensure accurate representation and attribution of local cultures, preserve the authenticity of indigenous stories, and promote Pakistani cultural heritage in educational materials.

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